day as compared to the 90,000 cases per day which the country witnessed at the peak of the first wave. One of the main reasons why the Dr Paul-led empowered group concluded the inevitability of the second wave, close on the back of the peak of the first wave was because countries around the world were experiencing second waves with peaks higher than the first wave. In the 1918 flu pandemic, the second wave had killed more people than the first. They thus concurred, ‘The more the infections in the first wave were suppressed early on, the more likely we were to get a recurrence at some point. Calculating the rate of recurrence of the second wave based on the impact of artificial measures like lockdowns used for suppressions of infections during the first wave was a very difficult challenge.’ To elaborate, if the peak of the first wave was kept artificially low, there would inevitably be a second wave. India’s placement to face the second wave would be calculated by considering the amount of people inoculated with our approved vaccines in addition to the amount of population with immunity after the first wave. However, with the virus mutating, the two unknowns which remained like dangling knives on our heads were: there was no way to predict the timing of the impending wave due to the unknown nature of the new variants and that there was no way to ascertain the extent of fatality they would cause. However, back in September 2020, when Dr Paul had presented his Group’s report, the PMO had sanctioned ₹200 crore from the PM CARES fund, for installing 162 dedicated Pressure Swing Adsorption (PSA) medical oxygen generation plants in public health facilities. Ninety-two were planned to be ready by March, 59 by April and the rest by May 2021.

1 MARCH 2021

INDIA | 1,68,665 ACTIVE CASES | 1,58,396 DEATHS | 1.22 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

WORLD | 1,47,01,140 ACTIVE CASES | 26,68,765 DEATHS | 15.19 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

The day began with the prime minister leaving from his residence for AIIMS in Delhi, where he was scheduled to take the first shot of Covaxin. Today marked the day when India had opened up its vaccination drive to